



Custom made cockpit

Gamer builds a custom rig with three projectors and head tracking to play Elite: Dangerous <http://dgit.in/GamerShip>



Blood Sport suspended

Kickstarter project that collected blood when you actually lose blood during a game was suspended <http://dgit.in/BloodGame>



Flickering into focus

One of the largest repositories of public domain images on the Web, Flickr allows you up to 1TB of free image storage. No mean feat. Not settling on its laurels, the service's leading matador, Bernardo Hernandez, drops his guard to discuss the core values of the beloved photo-sharing site, and also the technology that makes it tick. Excerpts:

◀ Bernardo Hernandez
Flickr

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Q Are there any plans to integrate videos into Flickr in a larger way? Bigger play on videos in the future? Take on YouTube, for instance?

Bernardo: Video is a critical part of today's visual content. However, we want to concentrate on photography for now. Right now, you can actually upload up to 3 minutes of video from your desktop and from your phone you can upload up to 30 seconds of video. Right now, according to the feedback from our community, we're serving the basic needs for video well, and our plan is to keep increasing that capacity. As we update our infrastructure, we will keep supporting video to the best of our abilities – without any intention of becoming a video site. Flickr's all about photography, we mustn't forget.

Q Why does Flickr still lack a comprehensive software tool for bulk uploading photos from a desktop?

Bernardo: Previously, we had a cap of batch uploading 500 photos through the Web browser, but there's no cap anymore – we removed the batch uploading cap a few months ago to make it slightly more easier for Flickr users to bulk upload photos. But you're absolutely right, there's no comprehensive tool yet, and we're

working on ways to make it much easier and convenient from uploading from desktops, and we're going to have good news for you very soon.

Q How does Flickr compare to Instagram? Any thoughts on the rivalry?

Bernardo: The photography space is huge right now. It's easily one of the largest categories of content on the Web – it's the second largest content revolutions on the Web after email, in fact. And there's space for many providers and they can be very successful by providing a specific solution to their users. We have no intention of becoming Instagram at all. We believe Instagram does what it does really well which is all about capturing a moment, sharing that moment for instant gratification. But they have many limitations when it comes to photography – things like only one aspect ratio, low resolution pictures, no way of organizing your picture, etc. But Instagram does something very unique and therefore they've been so successful. We're very complementary to each other. Flickr wants to be the platform where all those things happen. We want to give users a photography platform that makes organizing, managing and sharing your pictures with the people that you care about in an effective way. That's where we're different from the competition, as no one's really doing that.

Q Explain to us the kind of technology that keeps Flickr running?

Bernardo: Sure. As you can imagine, we're one of the largest repositories of freely usable public domain photographs in the world, and to power the whole experience our infrastructure has around 7000 servers, the site was written in PHP, we have around 200 APIs, all running on technology that's 10 years old. We're migrating to a more data-enabled technology, better integrating with the infrastructure of Yahoo. We believe that reliability and performance is a feature, so serving the photos as fast as we can, trying to reduce latencies, etc, is critical to our services.

Q The future of photography, and Flickr, will see a big push into mobile?

Bernardo: From the beginning, we've been trying to do mobile first. We still have more users using Flickr on desktop than on mobile phones. But in recent times, mobile traffic is growing super fast both in uploads and consumption. From the development perspective, the mobile experience is where most features of Flickr are debuting first. So in many ways, we're committed to serving our mobile users first. But we haven't forgotten that we have a very large chunk of our users accessing Flickr only through desktop. We remain committed to serving them. **Q**